
A W O R K B O O K B Y C A R R I E D A V I D S O N

THE

Conscious *Creation*

WORKBOOK

Find your flow. Break the loop. Build an intentional life.

C A R R I E D A V I D S O N

RN · Trauma Recovery Coach

carriedavidson.com

FIRST EDITION · 2026

The Conscious Creation Workbook

Find your flow. Break the loop. Build an intentional life.

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carriedavidson.com

Before You Begin

This workbook can surface strong feelings. That is not a sign something is wrong, it is a sign the work is landing. If anything feels too large to hold alone, please reach out to someone you trust before continuing.

CRISIS RESOURCES

988	Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, call or text 988
741741	Crisis Text Line, text HOME to 741741
1-800-662-4357	SAMHSA Helpline, free, confidential, 24/7

My therapist or support person, and how to reach them:

A trusted person I can call if I need to step away:

My first regulation step if I feel overwhelmed:

A Note on This Framework

Conscious Creation is my synthesis. I want to name that clearly at the start.

What you are about to work through is not a method I discovered. It is an integration of established practices from the fields I have spent the last decade inside, both as a CPTSD survivor and as a registered nurse. Specifically, this workbook draws from:

- Polyvagal theory, the three-state nervous system model developed by Stephen Porges and made accessible through the work of Deb Dana. The map on the next page comes from this tradition.
- Internal Family Systems, developed by Richard Schwartz, which gives us the language of witnessing parts of ourselves without becoming them.
- Dialectical Behavior Therapy, developed by Marsha Linehan, particularly the distress tolerance and emotion regulation skills that inform the activation protocol in Part Three.
- Flow research, originating with Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi and extended by Steven Kotler and others, which establishes creative flow states as neurologically distinct from rumination and self-referential thought.
- Complex PTSD recovery work, particularly the writing of Pete Walker, Bessel van der Kolk, and Stephanie Foo, who have built the framework most survivors of chronic developmental trauma now use to understand themselves.

What is mine, in this workbook, is the integration. The five-stage progression. The emphasis on creative flow as a daily regulation practice for trauma survivors, which is an angle most existing frameworks treat as adjacent rather than central. The specific exercises and prompts. The language. The order. The voice that holds it together.

I am a registered nurse and a CPTSD survivor. I am not a licensed therapist, a researcher, or a clinician in any specialized trauma field. What I am is someone who has done extensive personal recovery work and clinical work, who has read widely and carefully, and who has organized what worked for me into a structure I believe will be useful for others who recognize themselves in the patterns this workbook describes.

This is not a substitute for therapy. It is a companion to the work you are already doing or are getting ready to begin.

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook is built around the **Conscious Creation Method**, a five-stage framework for moving from unconscious repetition to intentional creation. You do not need any prior knowledge of trauma, neuroscience, or any other framework to use it. You need only to be someone who recognizes themselves in the patterns it describes.

Move through the workbook at your own pace. There is no timeline. Some exercises take five minutes. Some take days. Some need to be returned to as the work deepens.

FLOW NOTE

The creative flow exercises woven throughout are the heart of this workbook. They are not optional extras. They are the mechanism.

ONE

Witness

The nervous system, the somatic check-in, mapping your baseline. First creative flow discovery.

TWO

Understand

The first map, the loop, where it came from. Connecting your origin story to your creative self.

THREE

Interrupt

The activation protocol, the pause, regulation tools. Creative flow as a daily regulation practice.

FOUR

Create

Finding your flow in depth. The discovery questions. Daily creative practice. Conscious language. Gratitude.

FIVE

Sustain

The corrected map. Boundaries. Earned security. Daily check-in. Letter to your future self.

C O N T E N T S

Table of Contents

P A R T O N E

Witness

Making the unconscious conscious

- EX 1.1 The Somatic Check-In · Your Daily Foundation
- EX 1.2 Mapping Your Nervous System Baseline
- EX 1.3 Identifying Your Primary Stress Response
 Your First Creative Flow Discovery

P A R T T W O

Understand

The mechanism underneath the pattern

- EX 2.1 The Somatic Check-In
- EX 2.2 The Chain in Your Life
- EX 2.3 The First Map
- EX 2.4 Tracing the Origin
 Flow Discovery · Part Two

P A R T T H R E E

Interrupt

Building the pause between trigger and response

- EX 3.1 The Somatic Check-In
- EX 3.2 The Activation Protocol
- EX 3.3 Building Your Personal Regulation Toolkit
- EX 3.4 Creative Flow as a Daily Regulation Practice

P A R T F O U R

Create

Finding your flow and rebuilding something new

- EX 4.1 The Somatic Check-In
- EX 4.2 The Full Creative Flow Discovery
- EX 4.3 What Creative Flow Is NOT
- EX 4.4 Conscious Language Practice

EX 4.5 The Gratitude Practice · Noticing What Is Real

P A R T F I V E

Sustain

Building the intentional life, everyday, also one

EX 5.1 The Somatic Check-In

EX 5.2 Gathering Evidence for the Corrected Map

EX 5.3 Writing the Corrected Map

EX 5.4 Boundaries as Conscious Creation

EX 5.5 Your Daily Conscious Creation Practice

EX 5.6 Weekly Reflection

EX 5.7 A Letter to Your Future Self

PART ONE

Witness

Making the unconscious conscious

“You cannot change what you cannot see. The first work is not fixing, it is simply turning toward.”

CARRIE DAVIDSON

A note before we begin

The Conscious Creation Method begins not with action but with awareness. Before you can choose differently, you need to be able to see what you are currently choosing, automatically, below the level of conscious thought, from a blueprint installed before you had any say in it. This section introduces the somatic check-in, a practice you will return to at the start of every section.

Your Nervous System, A Simple Map

Your nervous system processes information faster than conscious thought. It moves through three basic states.

Safe & Social

Calm, connected, curious, present. Able to think clearly and tolerate difficulty.

Fight or Flight

Activated, anxious, braced, scanning. Heart racing, difficult to think clearly.

Collapse & Freeze

Shut down, numb, heavy, disconnected. Often mistaken for laziness or depression.

People who have experienced chronic stress or early unsafety often spend most of their time in the second or third state, activated or collapsed, with limited access to the first. The Conscious Creation Method is a path back, not by forcing calm, but by slowly teaching your nervous system that safety is possible, available, and survivable.

EX 1.1

The Somatic Check-In · Your Daily Foundation

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Return to this exercise at the start of every section. Your body is not separate from this work. It is the work.

Find a comfortable position. Take three slow breaths. Move your attention through your body from head to feet. Notice without judgment, you are just taking inventory.

Where do I feel sensation right now?

Activation level

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

Nervous system state, circle one:

Safe & Social

Fight-Flight

Collapse

Quality of the sensation, circle any:

Buzzing

Heavy

Tight

Numb

Hollow

Scattered

Foggy

Steady

Open

Light

Warm

Expansive

Grounded

Alive

IF WHAT YOU NOTICED WAS PLEASANT OR POSITIVE

Pause here. Let yourself stay with it for a moment. Notice where in your body you feel it. Let it be real. Positive states are data too, your nervous system needs evidence that they exist.

What does my body most need right now?

EX 1.2

Mapping Your Nervous System Baseline

Think about an ordinary day, not a hard one, not a great one. Just a regular Tuesday.

My shoulders are usually:

☐ Relaxed☐ Slightly tense☐ Significantly tense☐ Braced

My jaw is usually:

☐ Loose☐ Slightly clenched☐ Significantly clenched

My stomach usually feels:

☐ Settled☐ Mildly uneasy☐ Persistently uneasy☐ Knotted

Quiet feels:

☐ Restful☐ Slightly uncomfortable☐ Suspicious☐ Unbearable

What does my baseline tell me my nervous system learned to expect?

If my baseline were a weather report, what would it say?

EX 1.3

Identifying Your Primary Stress Response

We all have a primary response, a pattern your nervous system developed to keep you safe. Rate each one honestly.

Fight <i>Control, anger, directness, needing to be right, difficulty letting go.</i>	☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5
Flight <i>Busyness, moving on, difficulty being still, always seeking the next thing.</i>	☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5
Freeze <i>Going blank, numbness, disconnection, difficulty knowing what you feel or want.</i>	☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5
Fawn <i>People-pleasing, saying yes when you mean no, putting others' needs first.</i>	☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Where does my primary response show up most clearly in my daily life?

Your First Creative Flow Discovery

FLOW NOTE

This is the first of several flow discovery exercises woven through this workbook. Each one goes a little deeper. This first one is just an introduction, a first question.

Creative flow is the state your nervous system enters when you are so absorbed in something that self-consciousness drops, the inner critic goes quiet, and time disappears. For trauma survivors, this state is one of the most powerful regulation tools available, because it interrupts the loop at the neurological level.

THE FIRST DISCOVERY QUESTION

When was the last time you lost track of time? What were you doing? Write the first thing that comes, not the answer you think you should give.

CLOSING REFLECTION

Return to the somatic check-in. Notice what has shifted since you began this section.

What is one thing your nervous system has been doing for years that, now that you can see it, you can finally offer some compassion to?

PART TWO

Understand

The mechanism underneath the pattern

“Negative thoughts become words. Words become actions. Actions become patterns. Patterns become a life. This is the chain. And it runs, quietly, automatically, until something interrupts it.”

CARRIE DAVIDSON

A note before we begin

Understanding the loop is not the same as breaking it. But it is the necessary first step, because you cannot interrupt a pattern you haven't yet been able to see clearly. This section helps you trace your loop back to its origin, understand why it made sense when it was installed, and begin to separate the pattern from your identity.

EX 2.1 The Somatic Check-In

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Return to Exercise 1.1 before continuing. Notice where you are before you begin to look back.

EX 2.2 The Chain in Your Life

Think of a pattern in your life that keeps repeating, in relationships, at work, or in your relationship with yourself.

Describe the pattern in one or two sentences:

Now trace it back through the chain:

The thought that usually starts it (the automatic belief underneath):

The word or story that thought becomes:

The action that follows:

The pattern it creates:

How old were you when you first learned this thought was true?

EX 2.3

The First Map

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Write the first thing that comes, not the answer you think you should give, but the one that lives in your body.

Love means:

People always eventually:

When I need something, people:

When things go wrong, I am:

Safety feels like:

The most dangerous thing I could do:

I am worthy of love when:

I don't deserve:

Which belief has caused the most damage? How old were you when you learned it?

EX 2.4

Tracing the Origin

The loop didn't begin with you. It began in an environment that taught your nervous system what to expect.

Earliest memory of feeling unsafe, overwhelmed, or like you had to manage something alone:

What decision did you make in that moment, about yourself, about others, about the world?

How has that decision shown up in your adult life?

THE COMPASSION PRACTICE

The pattern is not evidence that something is wrong with you. It is evidence that something happened to you, and that your nervous system is extraordinarily good at its job.

Flow Discovery · Part Two

FLOW NOTE

*The creative self that existed before the loop began is still there. It went underground.
This exercise starts to find it.*

THE SECOND DISCOVERY QUESTION

What did you love to do as a child, before anyone told you it wasn't practical, wasn't impressive, or wasn't enough? What made you lose yourself completely?

Is any version of that thing still available to you now? What would it look like to return to it?

CLOSING REFLECTION

Return to the somatic check-in. Notice what has shifted since you began this section.

What would it mean to understand your loop, really understand it, not as a character flaw but as an intelligent adaptation that has simply outlived its original purpose?

PART THREE

Interrupt

Building the pause between trigger and response

“The pause between stimulus and response is where freedom lives. Everything before the pause is automatic. Everything inside the pause is choice.”

CARRIE DAVIDSON

A note before we begin

Interrupting the loop does not require willpower. It requires a pause, a small gap between the automatic thought and the automatic action. That gap, practiced consistently, becomes the space where Conscious Creation begins.

EX 3.1

The Somatic Check-In

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Complete the check-in from Exercise 1.1 before continuing.

EX 3.2

The Activation Protocol

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

This is the most important practical tool in this workbook. Learn it before you need it. It needs to live in your body, not just your head.

STEP ONE

Name it

When you feel your body begin to activate, say to yourself: *I am activated*. Not *I am angry*. Not *I am overreacting*. Just: *I am activated*. This locates the experience in the nervous system rather than in a character flaw.

STEP TWO

Regulate the body

Do one of the following: hold something cold for 30 seconds · splash cold water on your face · take 5 slow breaths with a longer exhale · step outside and feel your feet on the ground · move your body vigorously for 60 seconds.

STEP THREE

Wait 30 minutes

Do not re-engage with the situation for 30 minutes. Set a timer. Before 30 minutes, your thinking brain is still partially offline. After 30 minutes, you have access to choice again.

Practice log · one week

Day 1 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 2 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 3 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 4 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 5 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 6 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

Day 7 Trigger / Tool used / What I wanted to do / What I actually did

EX 3.3

Building Your Personal Regulation Toolkit

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Everyone's toolkit is different. The goal is to know yours before activation peaks.

Rate each tool honestly:

Cold water / ice	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Vigorous movement	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Slow breathing	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Being in nature	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Music	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Creative activity (your specific flow)	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes
Being near someone safe	☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Sometimes

My top 3 regulation tools, in order:

The tool I always reach for first but probably shouldn't:

EX 3.4

Creative Flow as a Daily Regulation Practice

FLOW NOTE

This is where the creative flow work becomes practical. Not creative flow as a luxury, as a regulation tool. Something you use daily, the way you brush your teeth.

When you enter creative flow, your brain shifts out of the default mode network, the part responsible for rumination, self-criticism, and the automatic loop, and into a state of focused absorption. Cortisol drops. The inner critic goes quiet. The nervous system gets a break from its own noise.

The creative flow activity I identified in Parts One and Two:

When in my day could I realistically do this for 20–30 minutes?

What usually gets in the way of me doing it?

What would I need to protect this time?

Daily flow practice log · one week

Day 1 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 2 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 3 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 4 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 5 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 6 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

Day 7 Activity / Duration / How I felt before and after

CLOSING REFLECTION

Return to the somatic check-in. Notice what has shifted since you began this section.

Where in your daily life is the pause most available to you, and what would it mean to use it?

PART FOUR

Create

Finding your flow and building something new

“Creativity is the opposite of stuck trauma. Not because making things is magical, because the state of making something is neurologically incompatible with the loop.”

CARRIE DAVIDSON

A note before we begin

This is the heart of the Conscious Creation Method. Everything before this section was preparation, understanding the loop, building the pause, creating the conditions. This section is where you find the specific, personal, unreplicable state that interrupts your loop at the source. And then you build it into a life.

EX 4.1

The Somatic Check-In

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Complete the check-in from Exercise 1.1 before continuing.

EX 4.2

The Full Creative Flow Discovery

FLOW NOTE

Take your time with this section. These three questions together reveal your creative self, the one that was there before the loop installed its operating system. There are no wrong answers.

QUESTION ONE · THE LOST TIME QUESTION

When was the last time you lost track of time completely? What were you doing? Describe it in as much detail as you can.

QUESTION TWO · THE TRUE SELF QUESTION

What activity makes you feel most like yourself, not performing yourself, but actually being yourself? When do you feel most real?

QUESTION THREE • THE CHILDHOOD QUESTION

What did you love to do as a child, before anyone told you it wasn't enough? What did you make, build, imagine, or create before the world had opinions about it?

Looking at your three answers, what theme do you notice? What state were you in across all three?

Your creative flow, in your own words:

EX 4.3

What Creative Flow Is NOT

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Many people dismiss their flow activity because it doesn't seem impressive enough. This exercise is for that.

Creative flow is not:

- Exclusively artistic (it can be cooking, organizing, running, solving problems, deep conversation).
- Something you have to be good at to experience it.
- Something that has to produce a visible result.
- A luxury or reward for when the important things are done.
- The same for everyone.

Have you been dismissing your flow activity as 'not good enough'? What did you tell yourself about it?

What would change if you treated your creative flow as medicine, as important as sleep or food?

EX 4.4

Conscious Language Practice

Thoughts become words. Words create the atmosphere you live inside. Conscious language is the practice of noticing the words you use automatically, and choosing more accurate ones.

Three things you say about yourself regularly that came from the first map:

Now rewrite each one, not as a forced affirmation, but as a more accurate description:

OLD LANGUAGE 1	MORE ACCURATE

OLD LANGUAGE 2	MORE ACCURATE

OLD LANGUAGE 3	MORE ACCURATE

EX 4.5

The Gratitude Practice · Noticing What Is Real

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

This is not toxic positivity. This is a deliberate act of noticing, choosing where to put your attention, which is the most fundamental act of Conscious Creation.

Gratitude rewires the brain's default negativity bias over time. Not by denying what is hard, but by actively and deliberately noticing what is also real and good alongside the hard.

Daily gratitude practice · one week

Three things, one from your body, one from your relationships, one from your creative flow:

Day 1 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 2 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 3 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 4 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 5 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 6 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

Day 7 Body / Relationships / Creative flow

CLOSING REFLECTION

Return to the somatic check-in. Notice what has shifted since you began this section.

What does your creative flow give you that nothing else quite gives you? And what would your life look like if you treated it as non-negotiable?

PART FIVE

Sustain

Building the intentional life, one day at a time

“Healing is not linear. It is not a destination. It arrives in accumulations so small you sometimes can't see them until you turn around and realize how far you've traveled.”

CARRIE DAVIDSON

A note before we begin

The fifth stage is not an endpoint. It is a practice, the daily, unglamorous, deeply worthwhile work of choosing Conscious Creation over and over again, long enough that the new pattern becomes as automatic as the old one was. Not perfect. Not finished. Just sustained.

EX 5.1

The Somatic Check-In

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Notice how different this check-in feels from the first time you did it. That difference is the work.

EX 5.2

Gathering Evidence for the Corrected Map

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

The corrected map is built on actual, lived, embodied experiences that contradict the first map. Not affirmations, evidence.

A time someone showed up consistently without eventually leaving:

A time I was fully myself with someone and was not rejected:

A time I asked for what I needed and it was given:

A time safety turned out to be real rather than a setup:

A time I survived conflict without it destroying the relationship:

A time I was loved on a bad day, not just a good one:

What would it mean to give these experiences equal weight to the ones that confirmed the first map?

EX 5.3

Writing the Corrected Map

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Rewrite each belief as the direction you are choosing to move in, not a finished truth, but an intention.

ORIGINAL

Love means:

.....

.....

CORRECTED

Love can also mean:

.....

.....

ORIGINAL

People always eventually:

.....

.....

CORRECTED

People are also capable of:

.....

.....

ORIGINAL

I am worthy of love when:

.....

.....

CORRECTED

I am worthy of love:

.....

.....

ORIGINAL

Safety feels like:

.....

.....

CORRECTED

Safety can also feel like:

.....

.....

ORIGINAL

I don't deserve:

.....

.....

CORRECTED

I am learning to believe I deserve:

.....

.....

EX 5.4

Boundaries as Conscious Creation

A boundary is not a wall or a punishment. It is information, about what you need in order to stay present, regulated, and genuine in a relationship. Healthy boundaries protect connection rather than end it.

The situations where I most struggle to hold a limit:

What I am afraid will happen if I set a limit:

The first limit I need to practice, and what I would say:

BOUNDARY LANGUAGE TO PRACTICE

"I'm not available for that." · "That doesn't work for me." · "I need some time before I can respond." · "I care about you and I'm not able to do this right now."

EX 5.5

Your Daily Conscious Creation Practice

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

This is the daily structure. It takes less than five minutes. The consistency matters more than the depth of any single entry.

MORNING

Nervous system state right now (circle):

☐ Safe & Social

☐ Fight-Flight

☐ Collapse

Activation level (1–10):

☐ 1
 ☐ 2
 ☐ 3
 ☐ 4
 ☐ 5
 ☐ 6
 ☐ 7
 ☐ 8
 ☐ 9
 ☐ 10

My creative flow practice today, when and what:

One conscious language choice I am making today:

One thing I am grateful for right now:

EVENING

Nervous system state right now (circle):

Safe & Social

Fight–Flight

Collapse

A moment today where the old loop fired, what happened:

A moment today where I interrupted the loop, what I did differently:

My creative flow today, what it gave me:

One thing I noticed that was real and good, even if the day was hard:

EX 5.6

Weekly Reflection

The moment this week I felt most like myself:

A moment I interrupted the loop, what I did differently:

One pattern from the first map I noticed this week:

One moment of genuine safety or connection:

What my creative flow gave me this week:

One thing I want to do more of next week:

EX 5.7

A Letter to Your Future Self

A NOTE BEFORE YOU WRITE

Write to the version of yourself who kept going. The one who chose herself, imperfectly and repeatedly, over a long period of time.

Dear future me,



Return to the somatic check-in. Notice what has shifted since you began this section.

What is one thing you now know about yourself that you did not know when you opened this workbook? And what becomes possible now that you know it?

A FINAL NOTE FROM CARRIE

You came back.

You made it to the end of this workbook. That is not a small thing.

Conscious Creation is not something you achieve. It is something you practice, daily, imperfectly, against the resistance of a nervous system that spent years learning to do things differently. Some days the loop fires and you catch it. Some days it fires and you don't. Both of those days are the work.

What you are building, one exercise, one check-in, one creative flow session, one refused self-abandonment at a time, is a life that is actually yours. Not the one installed before you had any say. The one you are consciously choosing.

The creative self that went underground when the loop got loud is not gone. It has been here the whole time, waiting for you to come back for it.

You came back. That is everything.

Pick up the pen. You are not finished yet. Neither am I.

Carrie

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About Carrie

I'm a registered nurse and a CPTSD survivor. I built this workbook from the inside out, from what worked for me over a decade of recovery and clinical practice, and from what I've watched work for the people I've sat with since.

I am not a licensed therapist, a researcher, or a clinician in any specialized trauma field. What I am is someone who has done the work in her body, read widely and carefully, and organized what helped into a structure I believe will be useful for others who recognize themselves in the patterns this workbook describes.

This is the workbook I wish I had been handed years ago.

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